

Google Pixel 8

Too many tricks, too little refinement

So the Google Pixel 8 series is finally here. With the stage set for Google after the iPhone 15 launch less than a month earlier, the Google Pixel 8 series was launched with a lot of promising AI chops. In this review, I will cover what I like about the Google Pixel 8, what I don't like about the smartphone, and finally, if you should spend your Rs 75,999 on the new Google Pixel 8.

DESIGN

In terms of design, there isn't a lot of new stuff going on with the Google Pixel 8. The smartphone practically looks the same as its predecessor, but with minor nips and tucks here and there. The back panel also looks largely the same, but this time we get new colours! The camera visor is even thicker on this smartphone. Yes, the camera visor looks cool, but it is also the most inconvenient thing with this design. You can't place your phone flat anywhere. The saving grace here is that unlike the Pixel 8 Pro, the vanilla Pixel 8 has a brushed aluminium finish on the visor, so it doesn't scratch as easily. Up front, things are plain and simple. There is a hole-punch display which curves slightly around the extreme ends. I absolutely love this size, since it is super easy to use with one hand and fits anywhere in every pocket. Before this, I was using the Google Pixel 7 Pro as my primary phone and this size just feels much more convenient.

DISPLAY

Coming to display, this is where the Google Pixel 8 sees one of the biggest improvements. This time around, the vanilla Pixel 8 also gets a 120Hz refresh rate, up from the 90Hz on last year's vanilla Pixel 7, which is always great. The brightness is also brilliant. I tested this using a Lux



Meter under bright sunlight, and the Google Pixel 8 showed a maximum luminance of 1863 nits, which is again, one of the highest I have tested on any smartphone so far, only coming behind the iPhone 15 Pro.

Apart from having one of the brightest displays, the Google Pixel 8 also comes with one of the most colour accurate displays that I have tested on any smartphone. I put this display through a colour checker test and was pleasantly blown away with the results. The Google Pixel 8 in the sRGB colour space showed extremely accurate colours. With an average DeltaE of 0.9, the Google Pixel 8 has one of the most accurate displays out there. A lower DeltaE is considered better.

So yes, the improved display of the Google Pixel 8 is actually one of the biggest leap ahead for this year's Google Pixel 8 series. This 6.2-inch OLED panel is the hidden gem this year around. It looks brilliant and is right up there with the biggest flagships this year, like the Apple iPhone 15 Pro or the Samsung Galaxy S23 Ultra. In

some cases, the Google Pixel 8 also beats the other two biggest competitors so it is safe to say that this is one of the best displays on any smartphone currently.

PERFORMANCE

While the display is good, the performance on the Pixel 8 is underwhelming. The smartphone has issues like heating and software-based problems.

In synthetic benchmarks, the Google Pixel 8 fell behind its toughest competitors like the iPhone 15 and the Samsung Galaxy S23. I ran both CPU and GPU-based benchmarks on the Google Pixel 8, and the smartphone showed numbers that seem very low as compared to other flagships from this year.

Like every year's Pixel launch, the software isn't seamless. While there aren't any major bugs with the software, it's not as refined as one would like. At times, even things like making calls leads to a rather unpleasant experience, if you switch from earpiece to speaker often. Furthermore, I experienced a lot of call drops during my time with the Google Pixel 8.

I also found issues with the smartphone's Bluetooth connectivity. Even connecting to Android Auto wirelessly isn't very seamless and the smartphone keeps losing connection every now and then. Though a rare phenomenon, it shouldn't happen in a Rs 75,999 smartphone.

Further, at times apps take a while to open, the Google Pixel 8 takes a while to boot from shut down, and I have also experienced the screen going berserk while simply scrolling through social media. Furthermore, the standby time on the Google Pixel 8 is horrible. To make things worse, there is the heating issue. When I got the Google Pixel 8, the talk in town was about the heating issues with the iPhone 15 Pro models. But after using the Pixel 8 for a few days, the iPhone's heating issues didn't seem that bad.

The AI features on the Pixel 8 are also confusing. Many times, the Pixel 8 unnecessarily asks me if I want to turn on the live transcribe or live translate feature and even after clicking the cancel button, it turns on. Again, a rare phenomenon but super annoying.